

Cut those Wires

With the rapid growth of mobile devices such as palm tops and handhelds capable of word processing, a need for printing documents directly has emerged. This, in turn, has led to the development of wireless printing solutions. Many leading vendors have introduced printing devices that support wireless technologies such as IrDA and Bluetooth.

IrDA is an acronym for Infrared Data Association. IR devices work using infrared technology, and hence don't require cables or a PC to connect to a printer. Since they work using infrared rays, there should not be any obstacles between the communicating devices.

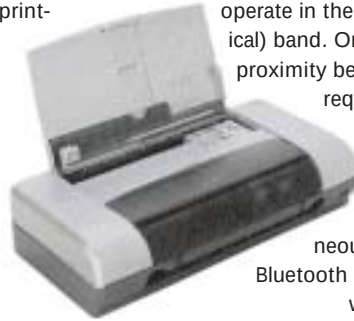
Some of the HP printers with IrDA support are HP DeskJet 340, HP LaserJet 5MP, and HP LaserJet 6MP, HP 2100M and HP4050N. Some of these are available in India and the rest will make it to our shores pretty soon.

Bluetooth is a late entrant. It is a low cost, low power, wireless, radio frequency technology that allows various electrical devices to

communicate between each other. Bluetooth devices operate in the 2.4 GHz ISM (industrial, scientific, medical) band. One of the advantages of Bluetooth over IrDA is that proximity between the communicating devices is not required—distances of up to 32 feet are accessible.

Moreover, Bluetooth does not suffer from line-of-sight restrictions. One fascinating aspect of Bluetooth-enabled devices is their ability to communicate with each other transparently and spontaneously, when they come within range. Thus, a Bluetooth enabled cellphone can be configured such that it will automatically print out all its stored messages using a Bluetooth printer as soon as you enter your office, without any manual intervention.

Bluetooth supports point-to-multipoint communications: a single printer can simultaneously connect to both your cell phone and your computer. The HP 995c Bluetooth Printer is one such inkjet printer with built-in Bluetooth support, though it is currently absent in the Indian market.



The HP 450CBI is truly a mobile printer with an IrDA and optional Bluetooth connectivity



speed test, but it proved us wrong by being one of the fastest. Upon investigation, we attributed this to its USB 2.0 interface. The Epson C61 took only 15 seconds to print the text document—standing second to the Lexmark Z65n, which took 14 seconds. It printed the fastest in the combination document test, taking only 27 seconds. However, while printing the image file, the 32 KB of buffer memory proved to be a bottleneck, and the printer took an unexceptionally long time of 749 seconds. The quality of printing, though, was unquestionably high. All these results accumulated in the STTI score of 84.

The Epson Stylus C82 came very near to its sibling, the C61, but lost on price grounds and thus scored 78 on STTI. Though there wasn't much of a difference between the two Epson's, on the performance level—both printers were neck and neck in the entire

test. The major differences were marked by the features—the C82 has separate ink tanks as opposed to the combined ones used by C61. The advantage of this is that you can replace the one that drains out first. Also, a paper thickness selection switch allows you to shift between the normal paper and envelopes, that are much thicker. The printer also shows ink status while printing and the percentage of the job completed. The Epson Stylus C82 was worthy of mention, even though it was Rs 350 more than the cut-off price for this application area because of its feature set.

One more printer that made its mark in the office-user segment was the HP 6122. This printer was also a tad above the price cut-off mark, but it made up with excellent output quality. It scored 80 on STTI largely because of the output quality rather than printing speed—it has a decent speed at printing both, text as well as combination documents. One point that needs to be highlighted is the difference in the time taken to print the image file between this printer and the Epson C61. While the Epson C61 is the fastest printer for printing text and combination documents, it takes very long time to print an image file. The HP 6122, though slow at printing text and combination document, wins hands down at printing image files. It has a mammoth 8 MB of buffer memory, which this makes this feat possible.

There were other printers that performed very well, such as the Canon S530D, which scored 89 on the STTI but was too expensive to be included in the office segment.

Our recommendation for an ideal office printing solution would be the Epson's Stylus C61. The reason is the performance that one gets for the price on offer; this professional looking printer costs just Rs 7,500, which is the right price for an office printer.

Professional Printing Solution

A professional printing solution is chosen on the basis of the pure quality it delivers, rather than fast speeds or nifty features. This application area demands the best hardware that prints at high resolutions, with next to perfect colour reproduction, and overall good image contrast and brightness. Along with these criteria, other features such as direct printing from camera, USB 2.0 interface for faster data transfer and bigger memory buffer are

